

sLight User Guide

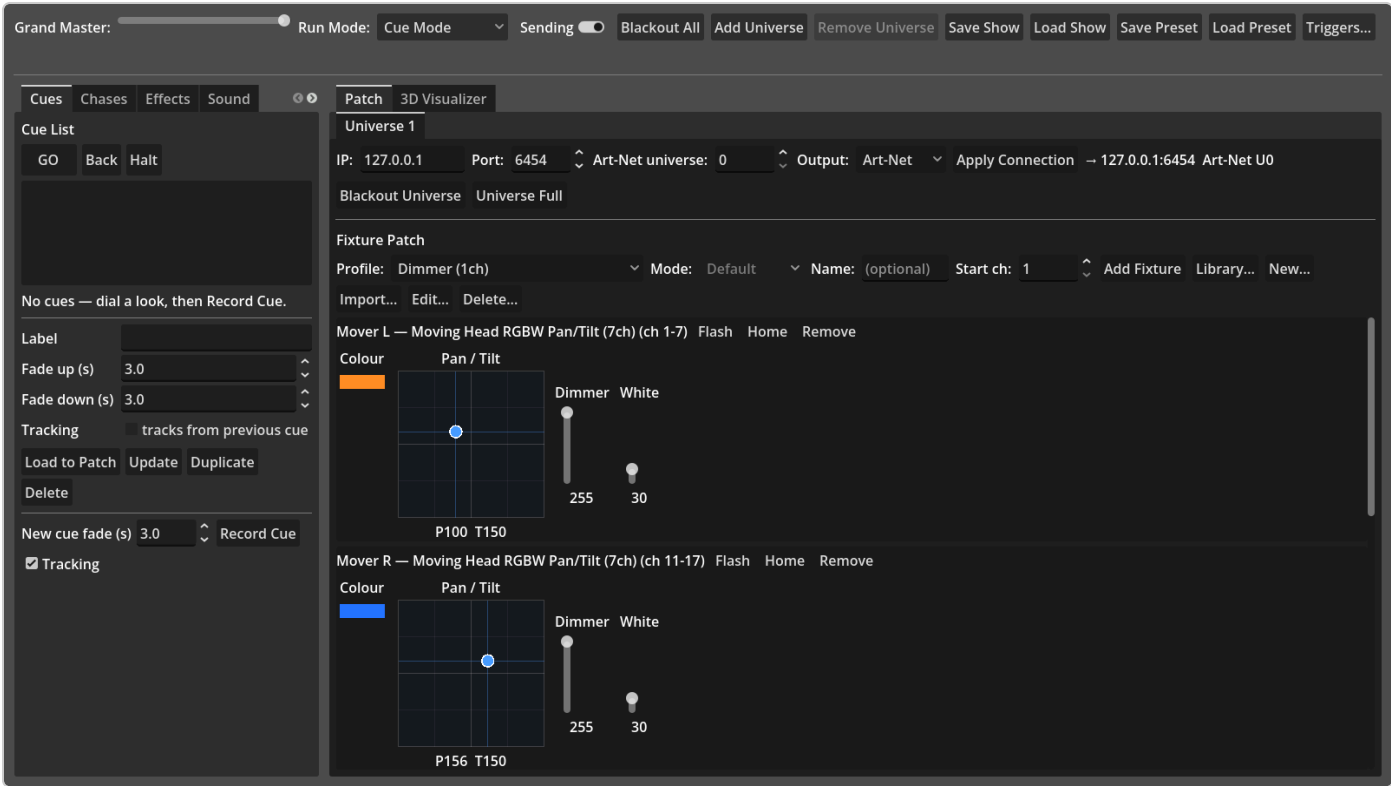
A step-by-step walkthrough for a new user, from opening the app for the first time to running a show. For a complete technical reference of every feature, see the [README](#) — this guide focuses on the essential workflow, in order, with screenshots.

What you need

sLight controls real (or simulated) DMX lighting fixtures. You don't need any hardware to follow this guide — see [Testing without real hardware](#) in the README for a free way to watch the DMX output live (QLC+ or an Art-Net monitor). When you're ready to control real lights, see [Going to real fixtures](#).

Launch the sLight application — there's no separate setup step, no account, and no configuration file to edit first. The whole window you'll see below is what opens.

The window, at a glance



The window is split into three areas:

- **Top bar** — Grand Master fader, the **Run Mode** selector, **Sending** toggle, Add/Remove Universe, Save/Load Show and Preset, and **Triggers...** for MIDI/OSC. These are always visible, whatever tab you're on.

- **Left side — playback tabs:** **Cues**, **Chases**, **Effects**, **Sound**, **Auto Show**, **Groups**. This is where you build and run a show.
- **Right side — Patch / 3D Visualizer:** one tab per universe for patching fixtures and dialing them in by hand, and a 3D view of your rig lit live by whatever the console is currently outputting.

Everything below walks through these in the order you'd normally use them for the first time.

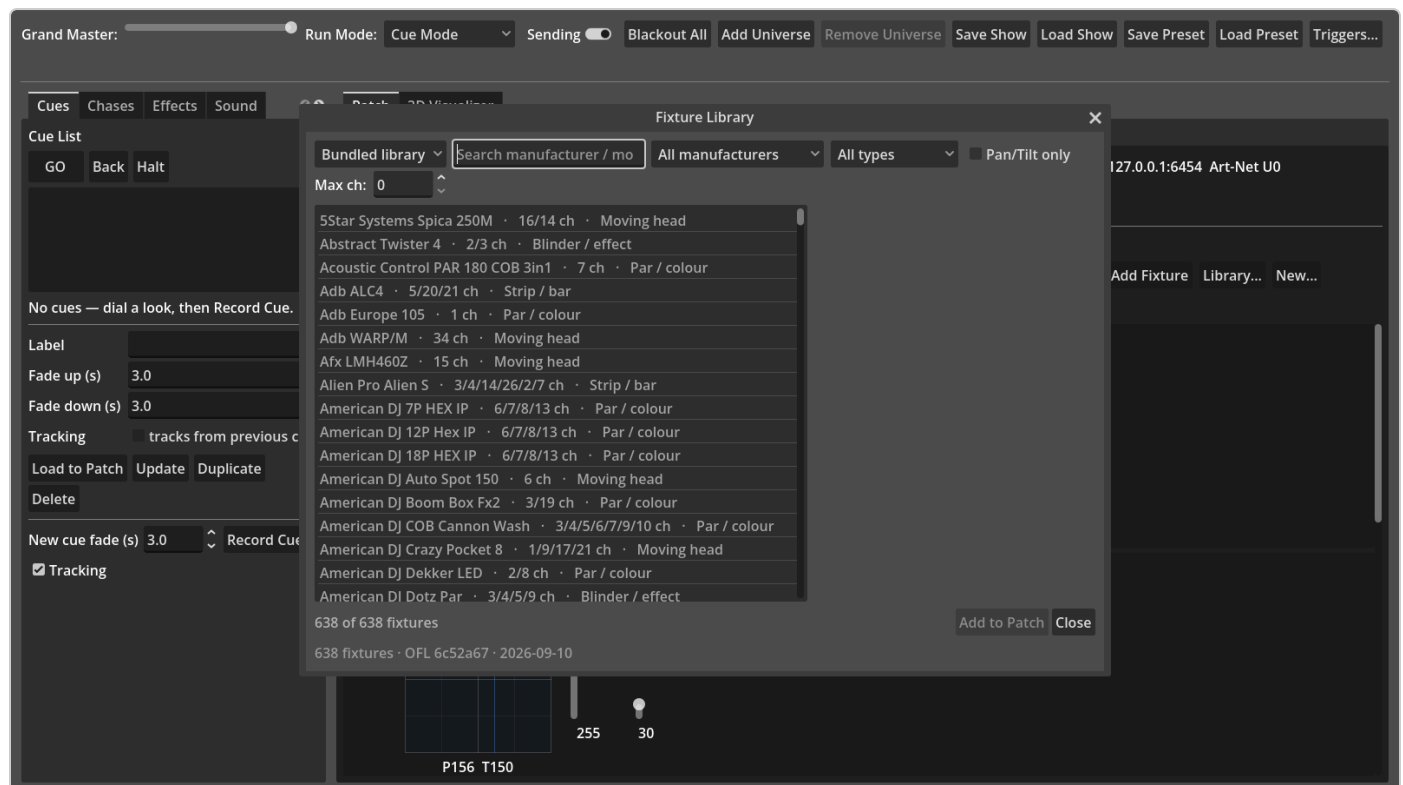
Step 1 — Add a universe and connect it

Each **Universe** tab (right side) is one 512-channel DMX universe. A fresh project starts with **Universe 1**. Pick an **Output** — Art-Net is the default and needs no extra hardware or plugins — set the target (for Art-Net, the IP/Port/universe number; `127.0.0.1:6454` universe `0` talks to a monitor running on the same machine), and click **Apply Connection**. Add more universes from **Add Universe** in the top bar if your rig needs more than 512 channels.

Step 2 — Patch your first fixture

"Patching" tells sLight what kind of light is plugged in where. In the **Fixture Patch** row, pick a **Profile** (a description of the fixture's DMX channels) and, if it has more than one, a **Mode**. Set the **Start ch:** to where it sits in the universe, optionally give it a **Name**, and click **Add Fixture**. Its control panel appears right below — a colour picker, a pan/tilt pad for moving heads, sliders for everything else (see the screenshot above).

A handful of generic profiles (Dimmer, RGB, RGBW, a moving head) ship built in, but real fixtures vary a lot — click **Library...** to search ~640 real fixtures converted from the [Open Fixture Library](#):



Search by manufacturer or model, filter by type/channel count/pan-tilt, preview a fixture's modes and channel layout, then **Add to Patch**. If you have a GDTF or Open Fixture Library file for something not in the bundle, **Import...** reads it directly.

Step 3 — Control a fixture by hand

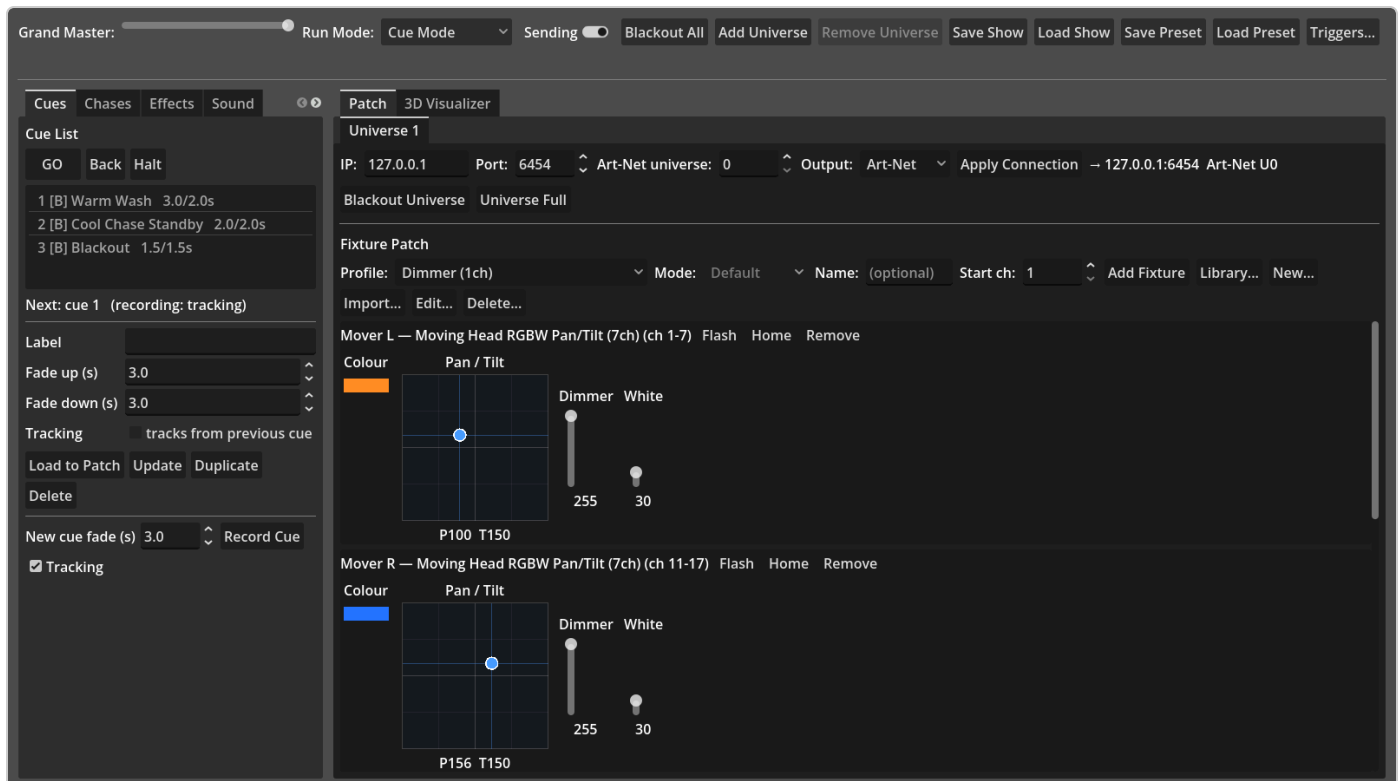
Every patched fixture gets purpose-built controls (visible in the screenshot for Step 2):

- A full Red/Green/Blue trio becomes one **colour picker**.
- A **Pan** + **Tilt** pair becomes a 2D pad — drag the puck to aim the head.
- Everything else gets its own slider, clamped to its usable range.

Flash (hold) snaps that fixture to full white and restores it exactly on release — handy for finding a fixture in a dark room. **Home** resets every control to its default. Fixture controls send live DMX output immediately (roughly 30 times a second, while **Sending** is on) — there's no separate "apply" step.

Step 4 — Record your first cues

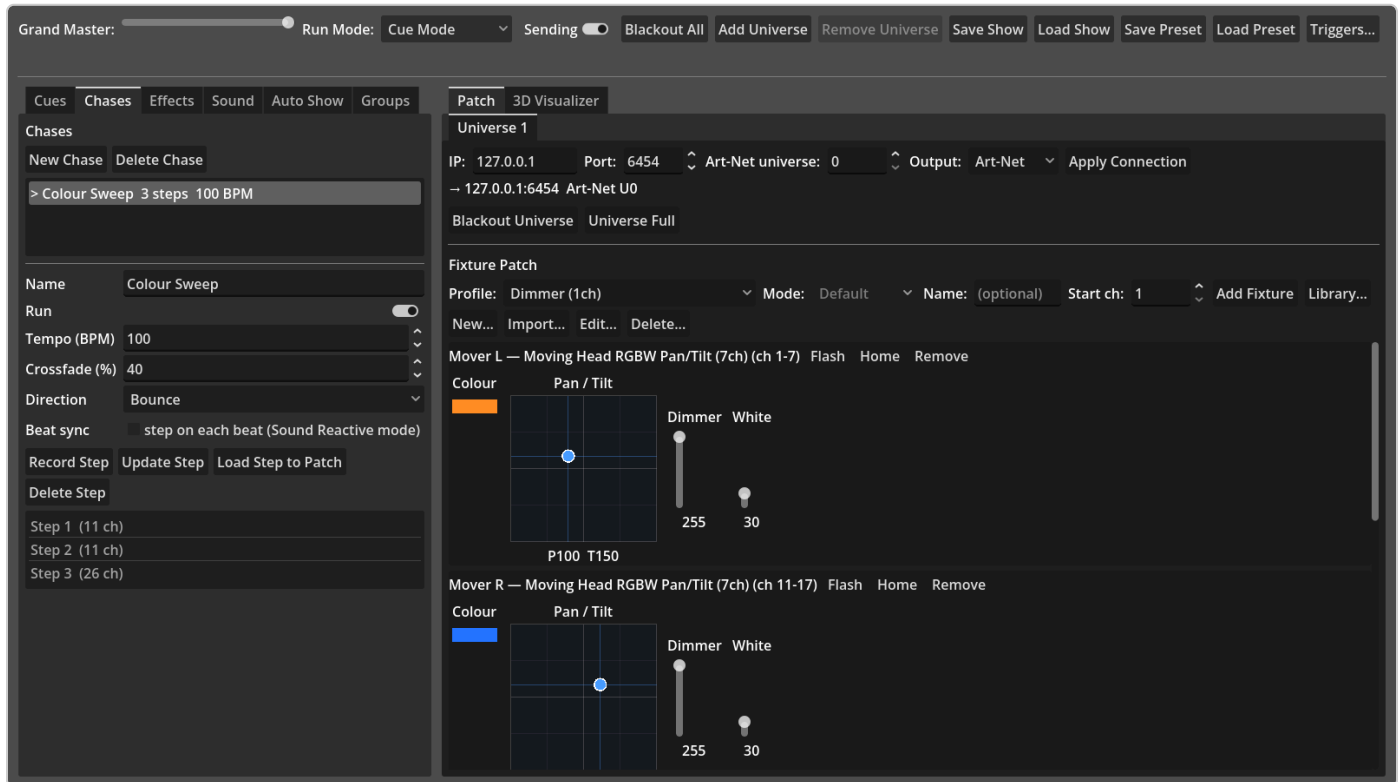
Once you've dialed in a look you like, switch to the **Cues** tab and click **Record Cue** — it captures the current output of every universe as a new cue. Repeat for a few different looks, then step through them with **GO** (or just press the spacebar) — the whole rig crossfades to the next cue's look over its fade time.



Select a cue to edit its **label** and **fade up/down** times inline. **Load to Patch** pulls a cue's stored look back into the fixture controls so you can tweak it and **Update** to re-record. See the README's [Cue list](#) section for the tracking vs. block distinction, which matters once you're editing a list of cues that build on each other.

Step 5 — Add movement with a chase

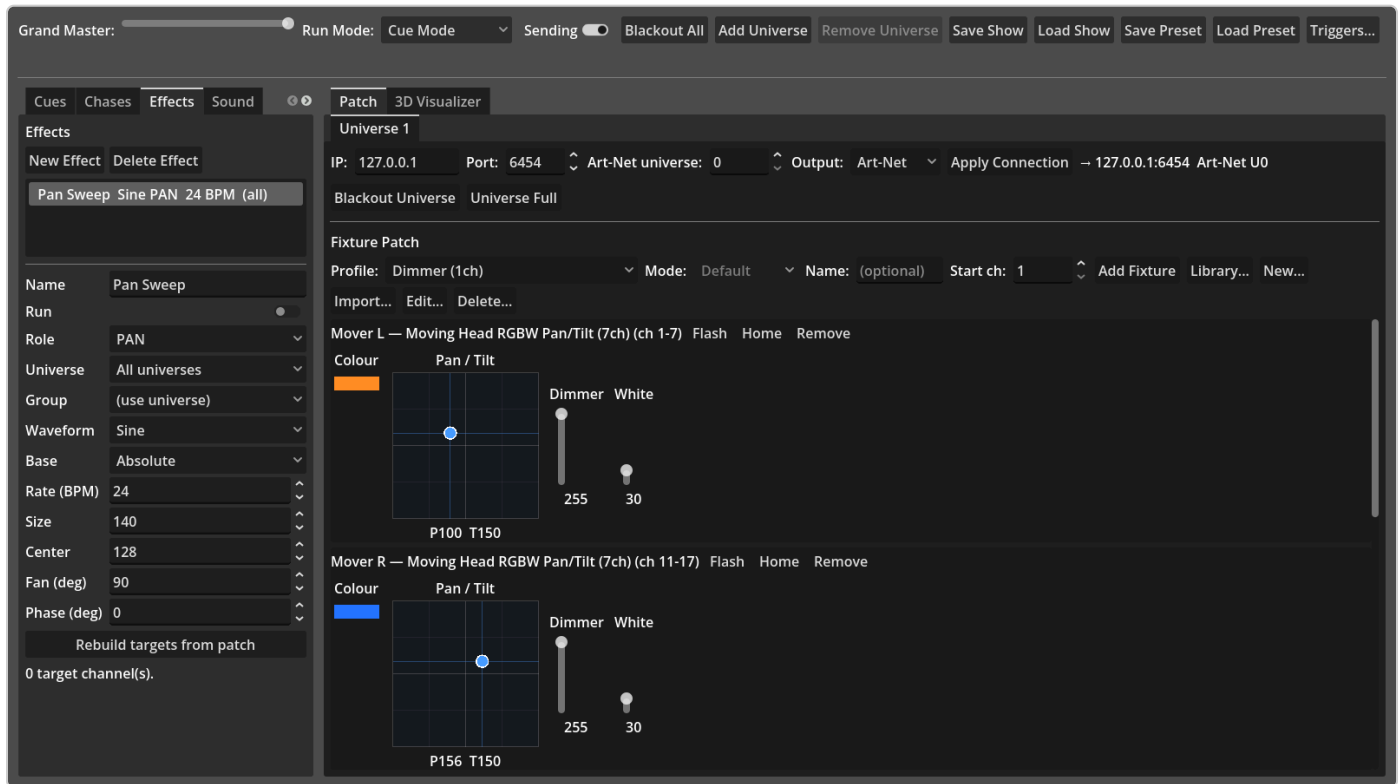
A **chase** is a list of captured steps that cycle automatically at a tempo — good for a repeating colour or position pattern that would be tedious to step through by hand. On the **Chases** tab, click **New Chase**, dial a look, click **Record Step**, and repeat for each step in the pattern.



Set the **Tempo (BPM)**, how much each step **Crossfades** in from the last one, and a **Direction** (forward / backward / bounce). Click **Run** to start it — a chase runs as a layer *on top of* whatever your cues are doing, so it doesn't disturb your programmed look, and stops cleanly when you turn it off.

Step 6 — Layer in an effect

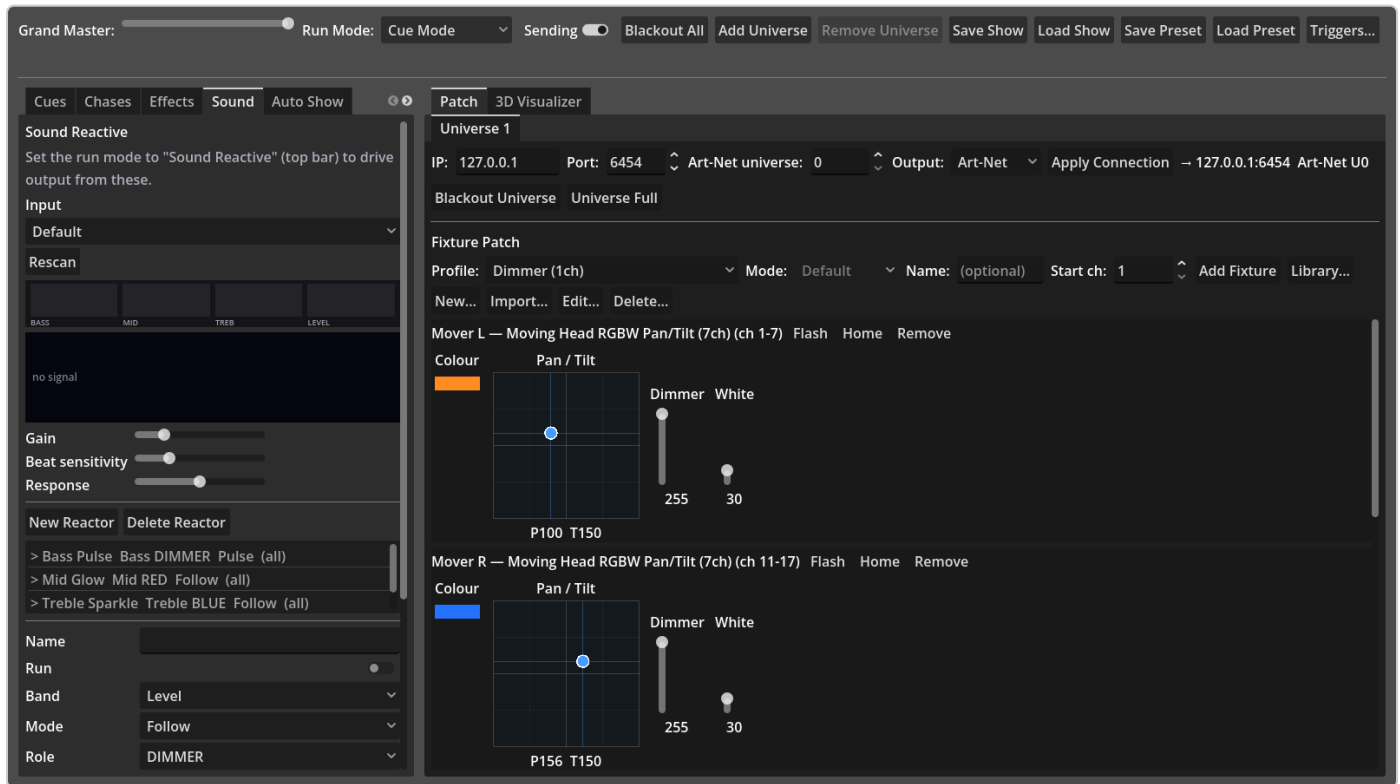
An **effect** is a smooth waveform (sine, triangle, sawtooth, square, or random) applied continuously to one channel role — a breathing dimmer, a Pan/Tilt circle, a slow colour swell — without needing to record any steps.



Pick the **Role** it drives and which fixtures (a **Universe**, or a **Group** — see Step 9), a **Waveform**, **Rate (BPM)**, and **Size** (how far it swings). **Fan (deg)** spreads the phase across the fixture list, so instead of every fixture moving in lockstep you get a chase-like ripple across the rig — try it with two Pan/Tilt effects 90° out of phase for a circle. Click **Run** to start it; like chases, effects layer over your cues without disturbing them.

Step 7 — React to music live

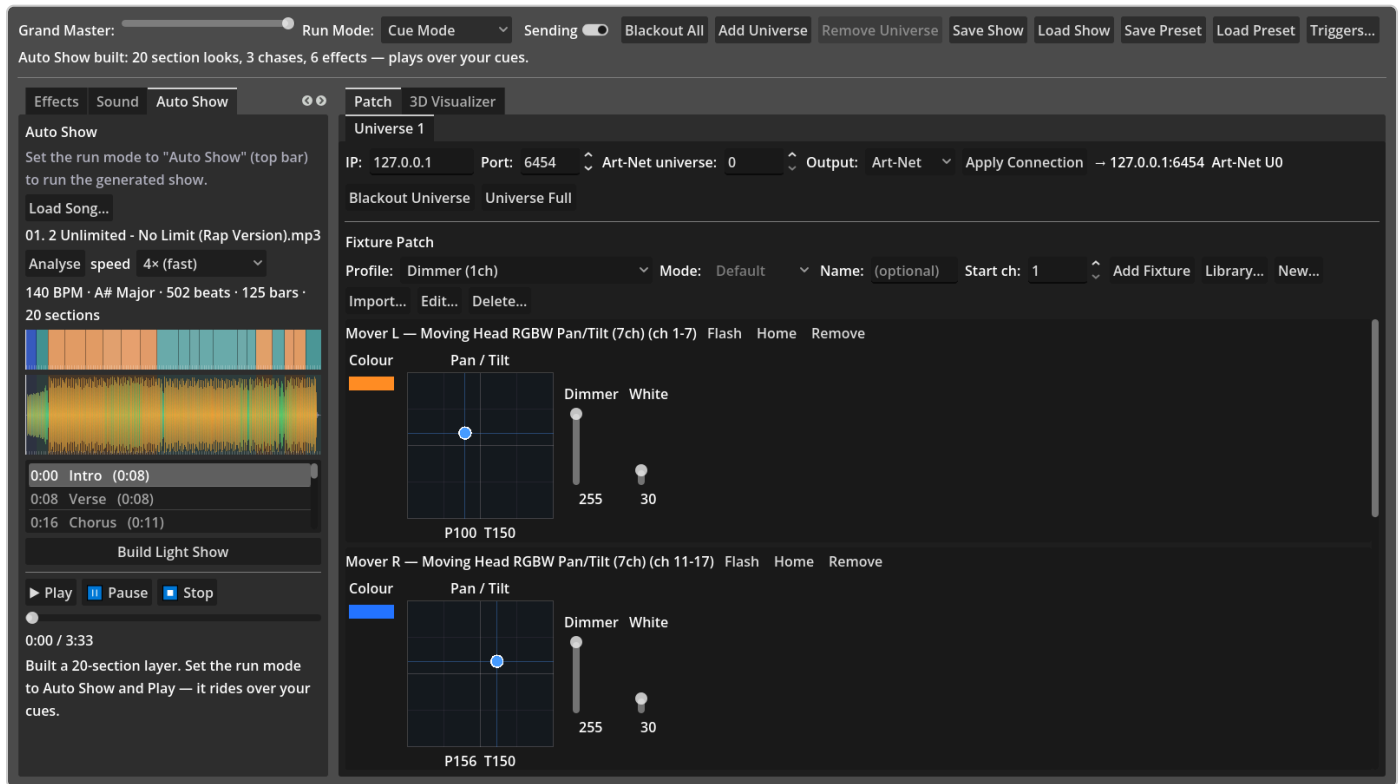
Set the top bar's **Run Mode** to **Sound Reactive** and switch to the **Sound** tab to drive output straight from a microphone or line input.



Pick an **Input** device, and a live **bass / mid / treble / level** meter with a spectrogram shows what's coming in. A **reactor** maps one band (or the beat) onto a channel role — **Follow** mode tracks the band continuously (bass into a dimmer swell), **Pulse** mode snaps to full on every detected beat and releases (a beat-synced flash). A starter set of four reactors is already here to try — **Bass Pulse**, **Mid Glow**, **Treble Sparkle**, and **Beat Strobe** (off by default, since it's a lot more intense than the others) — edit or delete them, or add your own with **New Reactor**. Tick **Run** on the ones you want active.

Step 8 — Auto-generate a show from a song

The **Auto Show** tab analyses a music file and builds a whole light show from its structure automatically.

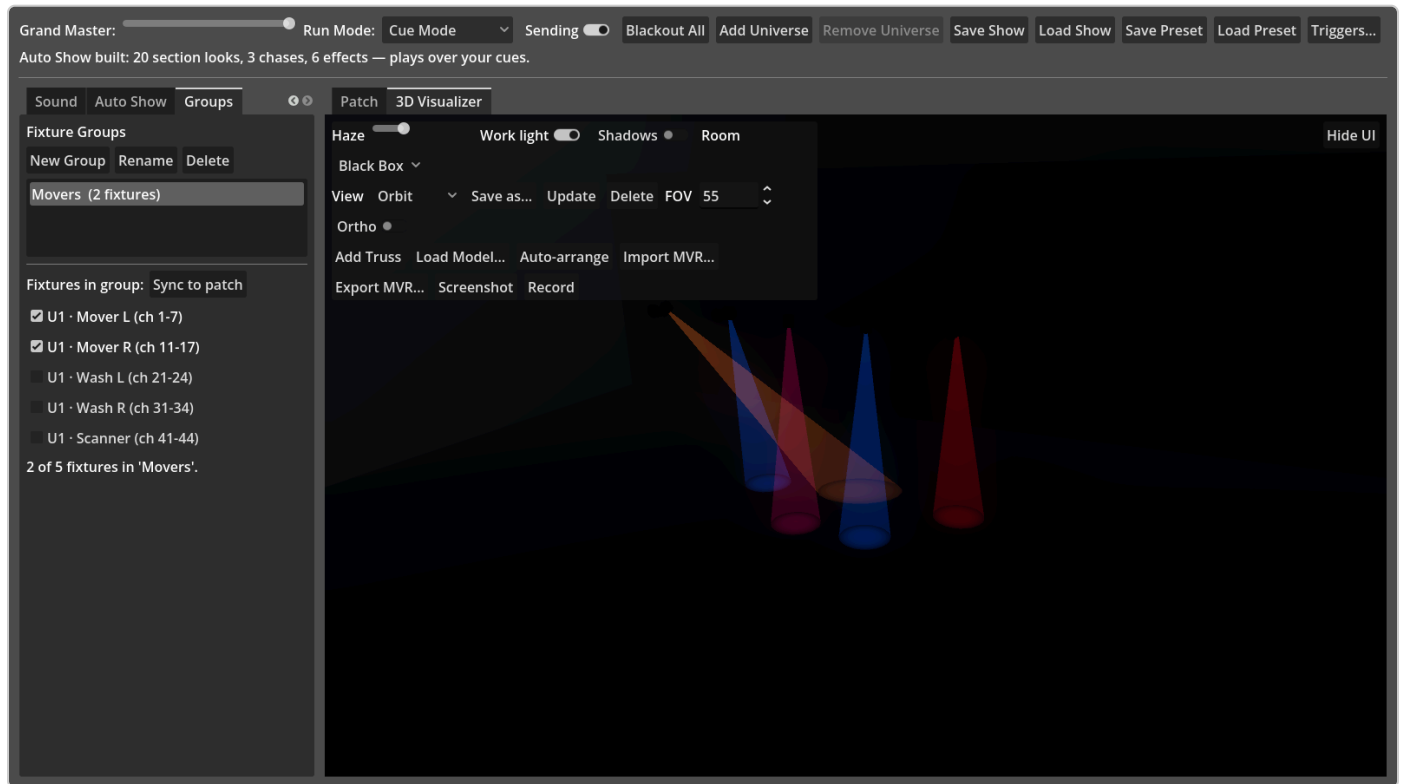


1. **Load Song...** picks an MP3, OGG, or WAV file.
2. **Analyse** works out the tempo, beat grid, and musical key, then segments the song into labelled sections (Intro / Verse / Chorus / Bridge / Build / Drop / Outro) by finding which parts repeat and how loud they are. The result shows as a **structure strip** over a colour-coded **waveform** — click either to seek. If a boundary looks slightly off, drag it (it snaps to the nearest bar); right-click a section to relabel, split, or delete it.
3. **Build Light Show** turns that structure into a per-section look for every fixture kind, plus three generated chases and six movement effects — the colours themselves follow the song's detected musical key. This is a layer, not a replacement: it plays *over* your own cues.

Set the Run Mode to **Auto Show** and press **Play** — the transport tracks playback position, and the whole generated show rides on top of whatever your cues are doing underneath.

Step 9 — Organize fixtures into groups

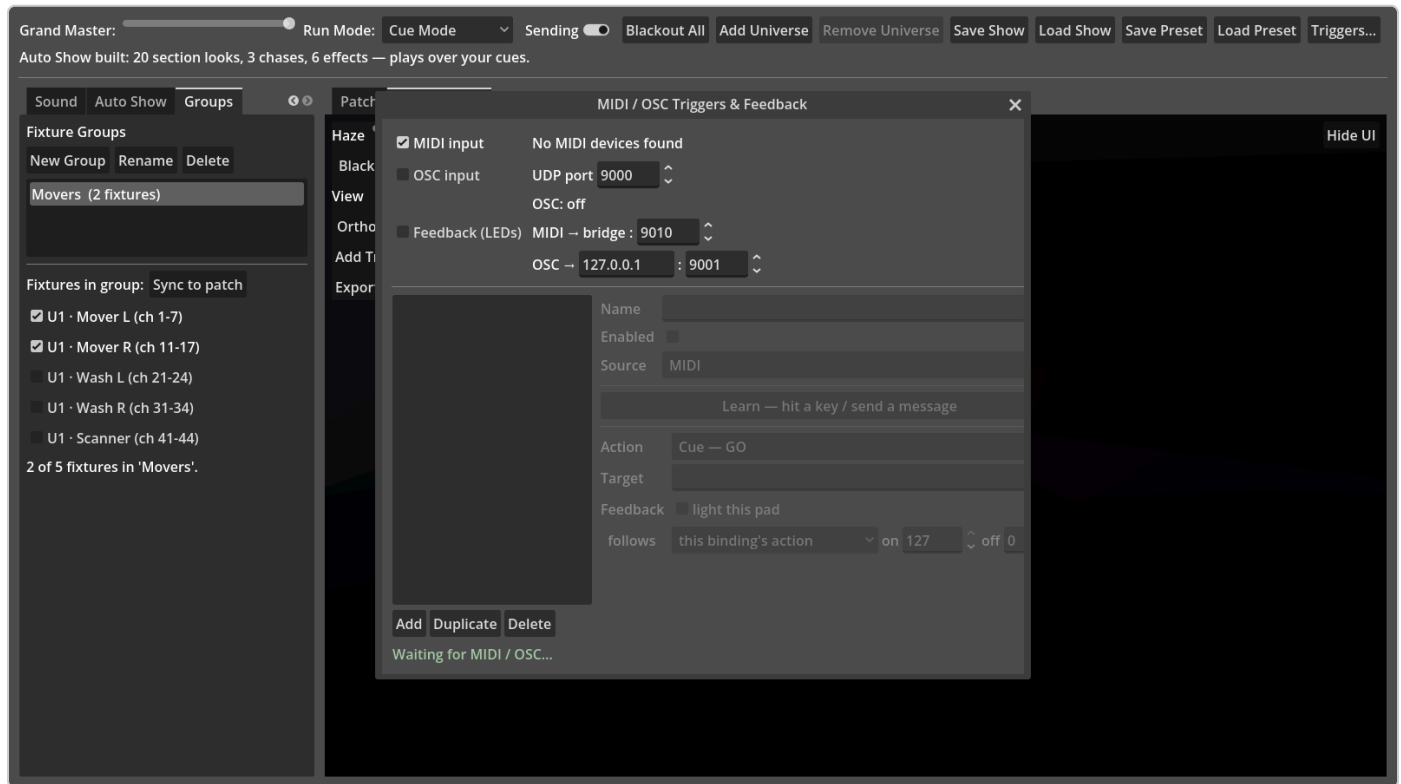
The **Groups** tab holds named sets of patched fixtures, so an effect or reactor can target just "the movers" or "the front truss" instead of a whole universe.



Left-drag empty space to orbit the camera, wheel to zoom. **Auto-arrange** hangs every patched fixture in a tidy grid to start from; drag a fixture on the floor (or type exact X/Y/Z and heading/tilt) to place it precisely. **Add Truss** and **Load Model...** bring in rigging and set pieces. **Haze** adds real volumetric fog so beams show up in the air; **Room** switches between a few preset spaces. **Screenshot** and **Record** save a still or an MP4 straight from this view. Drag the **3D Visualizer** tab off the tab bar to pop it into its own window — handy for a second monitor at front-of-house.

Optional: MIDI and OSC control surfaces

Triggers... in the top bar (works from any tab) opens the binding editor, so a MIDI controller or an OSC app like TouchOSC can fire cues, toggle chases/effects, or trigger a blackout.



Turn on **MIDI input** or **OSC input**, click **Add**, then **Learn** and play the pad / move the fader / send the message you want bound — the match fields fill in automatically. Pick an **Action** (Cue GO, a chase or effect toggle, blackout, ...). **Feedback (LEDs)** can light a pad back based on what it controls, or as a standalone beat/sending/run-mode indicator. This is entirely optional — most of the app works fine with just a mouse and keyboard.

Saving your work

Save Show (top bar) writes everything — every universe's connection settings and patch, cues, chases, effects, groups, MIDI/OSC bindings, and the Auto Show song/analysis — to one file. **Load Show** brings it all back. **Save/Load Preset** is a lighter-weight snapshot of just the live DMX output, for a quick "go back to how it looked a minute ago" without touching your cue list.

Where to go next

This guide covers the everyday path from an empty patch to a running show. The [README](#) is the complete reference — fixture profile details (multi-mode personalities, 16-bit fine channels, named value ranges for gobo/colour wheels), sACN and USB DMX output, cue tracking vs. blocks, MVR import/export, and every run mode's exact behaviour are all there if you want to go deeper.